

FOR BHARAT BHUSHAN Mehta, an avid tennis and badminton player even at 79, disaster struck during a tennis match about two years ago when the Covid-19 pandemic was on the wane. Attempting a smash, he sprained his shoulder badly. Mehta, who lived for the thrill of the game, tried to ignore the injury, popping pills and consulting some neighbourhood doctors. Nothing eased the pain, but he was not queuing up at hospitals.

Finally, in February 2022, when hospitals had reduced the number of Covid-19 beds and opened their doors to general patients, Mehta consulted a specialist. The diagnosis: Rotator cuff tear. Mehta was soon in hospital for arthroscopic repair surgery and recovered.

Mehta and others like him, who began getting back into physically active life with a vengeance after months of Covid-19 lockdowns and physical distancing, are unwittingly contributing to double-digit growth in sales of pain medications, analgesics, muscle relaxants, over-the-counter (OTC) drugs, and even implants.

Dr Deepak Chaudhary, Senior Director and Head of the Department, Arthroscopy and Sports Medicine at New Delhi's BLK-Max Super Speciality Hospital, who operated on Mehta, says even minor trauma can cause such muscle tears. The rotator cuff is a group of four muscles on each shoulder joint.

"As individuals age, these muscles can weaken due to wear and tear, and even minor or no trauma can cause tears. Many patients with shoulder pain fail to recognise the seriousness of their condition and resort to self-medication," says Chaudhary.

It's not just people getting back to an active life. Many have started lifting weights at home or taking up sports to get fit. Then many had to postpone elective surgeries because hospitals were focussed on the pandemic and were careful about admitting general cases.

THE MARKET GAINS FROM THE PAIN

Manufacturers of pain management drugs are pumped up and swaggering around, and why not? They are reporting robust double-digit growth in sales over the past two years, even as the size of the market grows.

Their offerings range from pills and sprays to lotions, ointments, and implants. An example is Smith+Nephew's Regeneten Bioinductive implant, launched in India on July 11 this year. Smith+Nephew reckons rotator cuff injuries in India added up to at least 150,000 cases in 2022, and just 28,000 of these opted for repairs. The company estimates that rotator cuff repair cases will rise to 33,000 in 2023 and 39,000 in 2024, a year-on-year growth of 15 per cent.

"The number of patients requiring such surgeries is increasing as patient awareness and knowledge about shoulder pain improve after the pandemic. For people now more active in sports and gyms, many surgeries could be avoided if patients seek treatment earlier,"

says Chaudhary.

As a class, analgesics, or pain relievers, have consistently grown at 4-18 per cent. Analgesics can be OTC or require a prescription. Analgesics as a class rank at No. 7 by sales in the Indian pharmaceuticals market after cardiac medications, anti-infectives, gastrointestinal drugs, diabetes pills, respiratory treatments and even vitamins (not necessarily in that order).

Pharmarack, a technology platform and software solution designed to streamline and digitalise the pharmaceutical supply chain, says the moving annual total (MAT) or the sales data over a rolling 12-month period, was ₹13,071 crore in April 2023 for painkillers and analgesics. The MAT for April 2019, or just a year before Covid-19 was declared a pandemic, was ₹8,894 crore.

The MAT for the muscle relaxants segment has grown by 20.75 per cent since 2019, to ₹355 crore in April 2023 (from ₹294 crore).

Sheetal Sapale, Vice President-Commercial at Pharmarack AWACS, says the pain market has shown a robust five-year CAGR of 10 per cent.

"Muscle relaxants, local anaesthetics, and anti-inflammatory drugs, which are relevant for sports-related injuries, have also demonstrated promising growth in the same period. This growth comes after a slowdown during the Covid-19 pandemic," says Sapale.

Going by the CAGR or compounded annual growth rate of companies dominant in the pain market over the past five years, Ipca Laboratories tops, followed by Sun Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd, GlaxoSmithKline Pharmaceuticals (GSK), Zydus Lifesciences and Micro Labs.

Ipca Labs reported a CAGR of 9.4 per cent, and Sun Pharma 8.8 per cent. Ipca's sales grew by 23 per cent last year, and Sun Pharma's by 14 per cent. GSK reported a CAGR of 4.3 per cent, followed closely by Zydus with 4.2 per cent and Micro Labs with 3.9 per cent.